Unlocking the gatekeepers

Technology companies have spent years explaining that artificial intelligence will dismantle inefficiency, democratise expertise and transform entire industries. Apparently, nobody thought to put an asterisk beside "entire". Because the same forces are now pressing against their own carefully maintained boundaries be it restricted hardware, proprietary software ecosystems or features sold through monthly subscriptions. The uncomfortable question is becoming harder to avoid: how much of a technology product's price reflects engineering, and how much reflects permission?

NVIDIA's consumer GPUs provide a particularly awkward example. The community GPU Unlock project reports lifting an RTX 3090 Ti's BF16 matrix throughput from 87.5 to approximately 157 TFLOPS by bypassing a restriction on Tensor Core execution. That is roughly 80 per cent more throughput in that test, from the same physical card. It does not translate into an equivalent improvement across every application, but the distinction between silicon capability and permitted performance is difficult to miss.

What makes the current moment interesting is the demand for affordable local AI, which gives technically capable communities another reason to investigate exactly what their hardware can do. Once an upgrade becomes a software modification, the premium attached to withholding that capability is going to be scrutinised.

Console enthusiasts are asking a related ownership question. Playden allows Windows games from Steam libraries to run locally on jailbroken PS5 consoles through a Wine port. It remains experimental, with compatibility limitations, but the proposition is striking, in the sense that hardware purchased for one storefront can execute software bought elsewhere. The machine's commercial identity turns out to be narrower than its technical potential. These projects should not all be credited to AI. Reverse engineering, compatibility layers and community persistence long predate LLM chatbots. The more credible argument is that AI assistance can lower the effort involved in understanding unfamiliar code, building tools and testing alternatives. It joins an existing movement whose objectives frequently conflict with the business models financing the AI boom. The irony becomes sharper inside AI itself.



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DeepSeek's R1 family challenged the notion that useful reasoning belonged exclusively behind a proprietary endpoint. Released weights and distilled models gave developers something more useful than a demonstration: material they could inspect, adapt and deploy. That doesn't make frontier research inexpensive. It makes exclusivity harder to sustain. A capability can remain costly to invent while becoming cheaper for others to reproduce or approximate.

Then there are subscription features. OpenAI released Whisper's code and model weights under the MIT licence, making capable speech recognition available for local deployment. That did not eliminate commercial transcription. It forced a more revealing distinction between charging for a capability and charging for the convenience, reliability and workflow built around it.

That delineation should guide the industry's response. Customers will pay for dependable products, thoughtful integration, support and saved time. Those are substantial achievements. A restriction whose main purpose is to preserve a pricing ladder is a less convincing proposition, particularly when the customer already owns the machinery. Nor is open tooling guaranteed to win. Distribution, infrastructure and convenience still favour large companies. Most people want their software to work without an evening spent troubleshooting dependencies.

That being said, the current direction is healthy. Techn companies have enthusiastically sold AI as a way to make scarce expertise abundant. They cannot reasonably expect every scarcity underpinning their own margins to remain untouched. If AI delivers even part of that promise, some of its work will involve making its promoters compete harder.